

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

In 1990, the then US deputy national security adviser Robert Gates flew down to the subcontinent on behalf of US president George Bush to broker peace between India and Pakistan. If American accounts are to be believed, the Gates Mission, as it was called, averted a fourth war between the two nuclear-armed neighbours.

Gates Mission-2 to New Delhi, nearly two decades later, as the second Bush administration's defence secretary, marks another significant milestone in the US engagement of India as a key partner. The initiative comes in the last lap of both the governments and the almost interminable pause in the Indo-US civilian nuclear deal being touted as the centrepiece of the relationship between the two countries.

Given that the Left parties had threatened to bring down the UPA Government even for holding regular military exercises with American forces, Gates, while pushing the case for an expansion in the Indo-US defence ties, was cautious in his public utterances. "We are building for the long



NEW GATES MISSION

Understanding the political opposition, the US defence secretary pushes for a stable, long-term defence agreement rather than quick results and separates military ties from the civil nuclear deal

term. We are not looking for quick results or big leaps forward, rather a steady expansion of this relationship in a way that makes everyone comfortable that we are not moving too fast. And that it works in terms of Indian domestic politics and works for us," he said in Delhi.

Gates was hopeful the Indo-US civilian nuclear deal would be formalised and made it clear that military-to-military ties would continue to be "independent" of the agreement. Here's why. From a market share smaller than that of Uzbekistan, the US share in the lucrative Indian defence market—conservatively estimated at \$50 billion (Rs 20,000 crore) over the next decade—is to grow substantially in the next few years to match those of

Russia, France, Israel and the UK. The US has bagged twin contracts—a \$1 billion (Rs 4,000 crore) deal to supply six C-130J Hercules aircraft and a \$2.2 billion (Rs 8,800 crore) one to supply eight P-8I Poseidon long range maritime patrol/strike aircraft to the Indian Navy and is competing to supply 126 warplanes worth \$10 billion (Rs 40,000 crore) to the Indian Air Force. As Gates said, "We ask for no special treatment. We are pleased to have a place on the table. And we believe that in a fair competition we have a good case to make."

Meanwhile, armed forces from both sides will undertake eight joint exercises this year to increase inter-operability, a ramping up of defence ties since the two countries signed the new framework for the US-India defence re-

lationship in 2005. Yet, it is key agreements like the logistics support agreement which figured high on Gates's agenda as he led a 50-member military and business delegation. He conducted hectic parleys with Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, Defence Minister A.K. Antony, Foreign Minister Pranab Mukherjee, National Security Adviser M.K. Narayanan and Opposition Leader L.K. Advani. While India is at an advanced stage of negotiations on buying defence hardware from the US, it is yet to formally initiate any of the, at least, five agreements governing various aspects from military logistics to container security, interoperability and end-user verification, proposed by the US in the past six years. Chief among them is the logistics support agreement